



Champion being just a few moves away from delivering a checkmate.

Nakamura was quite vocal about the relevance of the increment rule. "I know some people are unhappy with the time control, but I don't really have a problem with that," he told *Sportstar*. "And the concept of a tournament like this is to take chess to a global audience, to the casual follower."

The casual follower is who the league has been targeting. **Its CEO, Sameer Pathak, says the idea behind the league is to take chess to a wider audience by making it more attractive and fun to watch.**

"That is why we brought in ideas like the coin toss (borrowing from cricket) and, of course, the lack of an increment for this season," says Pathak. "We also employed the television production house that has handled major international sporting events across different disciplines."

The players appreciate the efforts the organisers have put in. "I understand what the league is based

on, being a cricket fan," says Peter Svidler, the Russian Grandmaster who made his league debut for Upgrad Mumba after being a commentator last year. "I don't know if it is going to be as big a hit as the IPL, but if that happens, it will be fantastic for chess. The calendar is quite busy, but this will be a very prominent part of it. It has a carnival feel to it while also being incredibly strong. This is a combination that has proven successful in other sports."

Svidler's team didn't have a great tournament, though. Mumba finished fifth among the six franchises; only Ganges Grandmasters was below it.

In the double round-robin league phase, Anish Giri's Alaskan Knights finished as the clear leader, scoring six match points more than Continental Kings and SG Pipers (the former's superior game points took it to the final). Nakamura's American Gambits, of which cricketer R. Ashwin is a co-owner, placed fourth.

Summit clash: Alexandra Kosteniuk (left) locks horns with Tan Zhongyi.

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

The Continental Kings were in a must-win situation against Alaskan Knights in what was the last match of the league. They won 9-7 to set up the final against the defending champion. **The final didn't go the distance, with the Continental Kings needing only two matches, which they won 9-7 and 13-7.** It was a close encounter, though. Alexandra Kosteniuk was the star. The former World Champion, who has played for Russia and Switzerland, won both her matches against Tan Zhongyi, the former World Champion from China.

Kosteniuk held her nerves, and her speed proved decisive. She played the queen's role perfectly in the Kings' campaign.

(The correspondent was in London at the invitation of Tech Mahindra)